During December 2003, it was announced that I would be the next GOC-in-C of Western Command. It is one of our most prestigious commands with its HQ at Chandimandir, a military station near Chandigarh. We felt very sad at the thought of leaving the pristine environment of the Shimla hills.

Towards the end of January, Shimla and its surroundings again witnessed very heavy snowfall. It was snowing in the morning as we left for Chandimandir and the road was covered with two feet of snow. It was sheer coincidence, but it had also snowed the day I took over the reins of the Army Training Command at Shimla, and it proved to be a good omen. Our Ambassador cars got stuck so we had to abandon them and get into 4x4 jongas fitted with non-skid chains to drive down.

Western Command is an operational command unlike the ARTRAC, which had no operational role. It was responsible for the defence of the western border from J&K upto Rajasthan during the 1965 and 1971 wars. Later, Northern Command was carved out from it to assume operational responsibility for J&K. Presently, it looks after the defence of the most politically sensitive and precious heartland of Punjab.

Therefore my first priority was to visit and familiarize myself with the latest situation in our area of operational responsibility (AOR). Though I had commanded 9 Infantry Division, which formed a part of Western Command, things had changed after Operation Parakram. We had realigned the theatre boundaries on the entire western border with Pakistan. At the end of my tenure as GOC 1 Corps, I had been entrusted by the army chief to do a study to bring out the lessons from Operation Parakram. Based on the recommendations of this study, the inter-command boundaries were changed and a new South Western Command was raised at Jaipur, as well as a new Corps HQ at Yol, about 70 kilometres east of Pathankot. This readjustment of boundaries came about after a lot of discussions and the overruling of many objections raised by HQ Northern Command – the objections smelt of petty turf issues. My first concern was to integrate the additional AoR in the Jammu sector into the Western Command plans. This arrangement would